

Tuesday, 18 August 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Light drizzle 25° 20°	BIRMINGHAM Drizzle 21° 15°	MANCHESTER Drizzle 18° 16°	GLASGOW Rain 16° 14°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

Wildfire phone alert was 'entirely appropriate', government says.

Millions of phones across England and Wales bleeped with a "severe alert" notification on Friday.

UK · NEWS
- 2

Cambridge chancellor criticises 'racist feeding frenzy' around Jason Arday.

Jason Arday, the former University of Cambridge professor at the centre of a plagiarism row, was found dead last week.

POLITICS · UK
- 3

Viral vodka brand Au set to sell for £500m to BuzzBallz owner.

The distinctive gold Au bottles have become a staple of poolside parties in Ibiza and Dubai.

UK · NEWS
- 4

Mrs Brown's Boys Christmas specials cancelled after star breaks jaw.

The sitcom's creator says he requires "immediate" surgery but hopes the show will return in 2027.

UK · NEWS
- 5

Monkey escapes from Highland Wildlife Park in Cairngorms.

The park was at the centre of a similar monkey escape that lasted more than five days in January 2024.

UK · NEWS

02 – SHOWBIZ

What's coming up

- 1 Hayden Panettiere: A life of struggles alongside screen success.**
She went from child actress to Hollywood star, but endured addiction, harassment and personal trauma.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 2 Emotional farewell to 'global, iconic superstar' Bonnie Tyler.**
Fans, friends and family travel to Swansea to pay tribute to Total Eclipse of the Heart singer.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 3 Mrs Brown's Boys Christmas specials cancelled after star breaks jaw.**
The sitcom's creator says he requires "immediate" surgery but hopes the show will return in 2027.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 4 'I want my brother back' - Tupac's brother tells BBC murder trial won't bring justice.**
The BBC's Shaimaa Khalil sat down with Mopreme Shakur ahead of the trial for his brother and late rapper's 1996 murder.
SHOWBIZ · UK
- 5 Tributes paid to Heroes actress Hayden Panettiere who has died aged 36.**
She starred in the TV shows Heroes and Nashville, plus films Remember the Titans and Raising Helen.
SHOWBIZ · UK

On the schedule

1

Scottish FA withdraws support for Fifa president Infantino.

The Scottish Football Association has lost confidence in Gianni Infantino and will not be voting for his re-election as president of Fifa, chief executive Ian Maxwell has told BBC Sport.

SPORT · UK

2

What England can expect from captain Root.

What can England expect from Joe Root's leadership, based on his first full-time spell in charge?

SPORT · UK

3

Is All Blacks' tour of South Africa a new chapter for rugby union?.

Is New Zealand's 'Greatest Rivalry' tour of world champions South Africa a signpost to the future of rugby union?

SPORT · UK

4

Pocognoli 'feels connection' with 'passionate' Scotland.

New Scotland boss Sebastien Pocognoli says the passionate nature of Scottish football was a key factor in his taking the job.

SPORT · UK

5

Ipswich sign midfielder Ouattara from Strasbourg.

Ipswich Town complete the signing of midfielder Abdoul Ouattara from French club Strasbourg.

SPORT · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new study suggests that taking a 'power nap' in the afternoon can significantly boost your creativity.**
Researchers found that even a short snooze can help consolidate memories and spark innovative thinking, making that mid-day rest more productive than you might think.
- 2 The delightful pastime of 'foraging for wild berries' is seeing a surge in popularity across the UK.**
Families are rediscovering the joy of identifying and collecting nature's bounty, turning woodland walks into delicious adventures for jams, crumbles, and pies.
- 3 A charming trend sees people 'decorating their garden sheds' with whimsical themes and colourful lights.**
These once-humble structures are being transformed into cosy retreats, mini-pubs, or even elaborate 'she-sheds', adding a touch of personality to back gardens everywhere.
- 4 New research indicates that 'listening to instrumental music' while working can improve focus and productivity.**
Without distracting lyrics, the melodies help create a calming background, allowing for better concentration on tasks, from office work to household chores.
- 5 The simple pleasure of 'baking your own bread' from scratch is experiencing a heartwarming revival.**
More people are discovering the therapeutic process of kneading dough and the unbeatable aroma of freshly baked loaves filling the kitchen, turning a basic staple into a comforting hobby.
- 6 A fascinating study reveals that 'watching documentaries about nature' can significantly reduce stress levels.**
The immersive visuals and soothing narration transport viewers to serene environments, offering a peaceful escape from daily pressures and promoting relaxation.
- 7 The delightful art of 'flower pressing' is blooming once more, as people seek ways to preserve nature's beauty.**
From creating stunning artwork to personalising greeting cards, this gentle craft allows for a beautiful way to cherish memories and natural discoveries.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to figure out if our clothes are clean enough to wear again, even if they've been sitting in the laundry basket for a day or two?

ANSWER: GIVING THEM A QUICK SNIFF TEST!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before enjoying a lovely, fresh biscuit from a new packet. What is it?

ANSWER: LOOKING AT EVERY SINGLE BISCUIT TO PICK OUT THE 'PERFECT' ONE FIRST!

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes you discover a 'quirky local tradition' or an unusual community event that's been going on for years, and it's just wonderfully British?**
What's the most unusual or charming local tradition you've ever come across in your area or on your travels, and what makes it so special?

- **We all have those 'unwritten rules' in our family or household that everyone just implicitly understands, even if they've never been formally stated, don't we?**
What's one of those unspoken rules in your family that might sound a bit odd to outsiders, but makes perfect sense to you all?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** Octopuses have three hearts: two pump blood through the gills, and one circulates it to the rest of the body.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** A group of pugs is collectively known as a 'grumble'.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The world's largest living organism is a fungus in Oregon, USA, spanning over 2,200 acres.
- The 'richest' soil on Earth is called 'chernozem', found in Eastern Europe and Russia.
- The average cloud weighs around 550 tons, roughly the same as 100 elephants.
- The British Library in London holds over 170 million items.
- Pineapples are not a single fruit, but a group of berries that have fused together.
- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are still edible.
- There are more than 2,000 different types of cheese in the world.
- A 'jiffy' is an actual unit of time, specifically one-hundredth of a second.

On this day

Day 230 of the year, 135 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Agapitus of Palestrina; Christian feast day: Alberto Hurtado; Christian feast day: Daig of Inniskeen; Christian feast day: Evan (or Inan). Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1969 — Edward Norton, American actor
- 1994 — Madelaine Petsch, American actress and YouTuber
- 1943 — Martin Mull, American actor and comedian (died 2024)
- 1988 — Jack Hobbs, English footballer
- 1971 — Richard David James, English musician and record producer
- 1957 — Tan Dun, Chinese composer
- 1936 — Robert Redford, American actor, director, and producer (died 2025)
- 1942 — Henry G. Sanders, American actor

THE DAY TODAY

- 1950 — Julien Lahaut, the chairman of the Communist Party of Belgium, is assassinated. The Party newspaper blames royalists and Rexists.
- 1963 — Civil rights movement: James Meredith becomes the first African American to graduate from the University of Mississippi.
- 1945 — Soviet-Japanese War: Battle of Shumshu: Soviet forces land at Takeda Beach on Shumshu Island and launch the Battle of Shumshu; the Soviet Union's Invasion of the Kuril Islands commences.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1977 — Steve Biko is arrested at a police roadblock under Terrorism Act No. 83 of 1967 in King William's Town, South Africa. He later dies from injuries sustained during this arrest, bringing attention to South Africa's apartheid policies.
- 2003 — One-year-old Zachary Turner is murdered in Newfoundland by his mother, who was awarded custody despite facing trial for the murder of Zachary's father. The case was documented in the film Dear Zachary and led to reform of Canada's bail laws.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1983 — Hurricane Alicia hits the Texas coast, killing 21 people and causing over US\$1 billion in damage (1983 dollars).

- 1937 — A lightning strike starts the Blackwater Fire of 1937 in Shoshone National Forest, killing 15 firefighters within three days and prompting the United States Forest Service to develop their smokejumper program.
- 2008 — War of Afghanistan: The Uzbin Valley ambush occurs.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 231 of the year, 134 days left in 2026. Today Afghan Independence Day, commemorates the Treaty of Rawalpindi in 1919, granting independence from Britain (Afghanistan); August Revolution Commemoration Day (Vietnam); Birthday of Crown Princess Mette-Marit (Norway); Christian Feast Day: Bertulf of Bobbio. Star sign Leo, birthstone Peridot.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1961 — Jonathan Coe, English author and academic
- 1969 — Nate Dogg, American rapper (died 2011)
- 1965 — Kevin Dillon, American actor
- 1982 — Erika Christensen, American actress
- 1946 — Dawn Steel, American film producer (died 1997)
- 1975 — Tracie Thoms, American actress
- 1980 — Darius Campbell, Scottish singer-songwriter, guitarist, and actor (died 2022)
- 1959 — Ivan Neville, American singer-songwriter

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2003 — A truck-bomb attack on United Nations headquarters in Iraq kills the agency's top envoy Sérgio Vieira de Mello and 21 other employees.
- 1964 — Syncom 3, the first geostationary communication satellite, is launched. Two months later, it would enable live coverage of the 1964 Summer Olympics.
- 1980 — Saudia Flight 163, a Lockheed L-1011 TriStar burns after making an emergency landing at Riyadh International Airport in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, killing 301 people.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2010 — Operation Iraqi Freedom ends, with the last of the United States brigade combat teams crossing the border to Kuwait.
- 1989 — Several hundred East Germans cross the frontier between Hungary and Austria during the Pan-European Picnic, part of the events that began the process of the Fall of the Berlin Wall.

Coming to cinemas

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome
SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar

AUGUST 2026

22–23

Belgian Grand Prix (F1)